

Until 1960 the crude birth rate remained high, fluctuating in the range of 35-42 births per 1000 persons. However, since 1960 it started declining steadily and stood at 30.1 in 1971. This decline in the birth rate is largely due to a rise in the average age at marriage of females and a reduction in marital fertility possibly due to increased use of contraceptives by married couples.⁵

Table 2.4 shows the average age at marriage of males and females as derived from Census data.

TABLE 2.4: AVERAGE AGE AT MARRIAGE DERIVED FROM CENSUS DATA. SRI LANKA 1946-1971

	1946	1953	1963	1971
Males	27.0	27.2	27.9	28.0
Females	20.7	20.9	22.1	23.5

The fact that women are marrying later in life than they used to is also brought out in Table 2.5 which shows the proportion of women currently married in the age groups between 15 and 34 years.

TABLE 2.5: PROPORTION OF WOMEN CURRENTLY MARRIED BETWEEN THE AGES OF 15 AND 35

Age of Women	Proportion of women currently married (percent)			
	1946	1953	1963	1971
15 - 19	23.9	23.7	14.8	10.3
20 - 24	68.4	65.7	57.6	45.9
25 - 29	84.4	84.4	81.0	73.5
30 - 34	87.1	87.8	88.6	85.9

The decline in the proportions married which is quite significant in the 15-19 and 20-24 age groups and less so in the 25-29 age group is a clear indication that women have been marrying at a somewhat later age in more recent times. This postponement of marriage is attributable to greater participation of women in education and employment.

Changes in marital fertility rates are shown in Table 2.6 below. It can be seen that the decline is concentrated at ages above 25. This is possibly due to the fact that married couples who have already had the number of children they desire have resorted to family planning to prevent further births.

TABLE 2.6: CHANGES IN AGE SPECIFIC MARITAL FERTILITY RATES IN SRI LANKA 1963-1971

Age Group	Age specific marital fertility rates		Percentage change
	1963	1971	
15 - 19	354	418	+ 18.1
20 - 24	396	388	- 2.0
25 - 29	344	313	- 9.0
30 - 34	270	237	- 12.2
35 - 39	175	157	- 10.3
40 - 44	53	49	- 7.5
45 - 49	8	8	-

5 For a detailed discussion see G.H.S. Jayawardhana and S. Selvaratnam "Fertility Levels and Trends in Ceylon 1967" and Dulles F.S. Fernando. "Recent Fertility Declines in Ceylon Population Studies Vol. XXVI, No.3".